

Word family: **theory / theories / theoretical / theoretically / theorist / theorize / theorise**

Base word: theory

Plural: theories

Related forms: theoretical, theoretically, theorist, theorize / theorise

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / related adjective, adverb, noun and verb forms (相關形容詞、副詞、名詞及動詞)

Your sentence:

> “He did not teach me through **theory** alone; he taught me through action, repetition, and example.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **theory** means **ideas, principles, or explanations learned in an abstract way, without relying only on direct practical experience**.

The contrast in the sentence is:

> **theory** ↔ **action / repetition / example**

繁體中文： **抽象的道理、原則或知識，與實際操作和親身經驗相對**

中文翻譯：

> “He did not teach me through **theory** alone...”

「他不是只靠**理論 / 道理**來教我.....」

Here:

theory = 抽象原則和知識，而不是實際動手做

1. **theory = system of ideas explaining something (解釋體系) — 理論；學說**

This is the central academic meaning.

Meaning: A set of ideas or principles intended to explain how or why something happens.

Practice 1

> “The course introduces several important economic **theories**.”

「這門課介紹幾個重要的經濟**理論 / 學說**。」

Practice 2

> “Scientists developed a new **theory** to explain the results.”

「科學家提出了一個新的**理論**來解釋結果。」

****theory = 用一組有系統的概念、原則或命題解釋某種現象的理論體系****

Common:

- * scientific theory
- * economic theory
- * learning theory
- * theory of evolution
- * theory of language

2. ****theory = abstract knowledge/principles rather than practice (理論 vs 實踐) — 理論 ; 道理****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** Knowledge or principles considered in an abstract way rather than through direct practical application.

Practice 3 — Original

> “He did not teach me through **theory** alone.”

「他不是只透過**理論 / 道理**來教我。」

Practice 4

> “The course combines **theory** with practical training.”

「這門課把**理論**和實際訓練結合起來。」

Practice 5

> “It sounds easy in **theory**, but it is difficult in practice.”

「這件事在**理論上**聽起來很容易，但實際做起來很困難。」

****theory = 抽象知識、原則或概念，相對於實際經驗、操作或應用****

This is closely related to Meaning 1, but learner-wise distinct enough to show because **theory vs practice** is a very common contrast.

3. **theory** = idea/explanation that may or may not be true (推測) — 推論；猜想；說法

In everyday English, **theory** can mean a proposed explanation that has not necessarily been proven.

Practice 6

> “My **theory** is that he left early because he was tired.”

「我的**推測 / 看法**是，他因為累了所以提早離開。」

Practice 7

> “The police are considering several **theories** about what happened.”

「警方正在考慮幾種關於事件經過的**推測 / 說法**。」

theory = 對事情原因或情況提出的一種解釋，但未必已有充分證據證實

This is genuinely different in everyday use from a formal scientific theory.

4. **in theory** = according to the idea, but perhaps not in reality (固定用法) — 理論上；原則上

Practice 8

> “In **theory**, the plan should work.”

「**理論上**，這個計劃應該可行。」

Practice 9

> “The system is simple in **theory**, but difficult to use.”

「這個系統在**理論上**很簡單，但實際使用很困難。」

in theory = 按照抽象原則、假設或設計來看，而不一定等於實際情況

This belongs to Meaning 2 rather than being a new core sense.

Related form: **theoretical**

Theoretical has two especially useful meanings.

theoretical = relating to theory (理論的)

Practice 10

> “The course includes both practical and **theoretical** work.”

「這門課同時包括實務和**理論**內容。」

theoretical = 與理論、抽象原則或概念有關的

theoretical = possible in theory but not necessarily real (理論上可能的)

Practice 11

> “There is a **theoretical** possibility that the system could fail.”

「**理論上**存在系統失效的可能性。」

theoretical = 根據理論推算可以存在，但未必實際發生或存在的

This is an important extension.

Related form: **theoretically**

Practice 12

> “**Theoretically**, the machine could run forever.”

「**理論上**，這部機器可以一直運行。」

Practice 13

> “The two methods are **theoretically** similar.”

「這兩種方法在**理論上**相似。」

****theoretically = 從理論、抽象原則或假設角度來看****

Related form: ****theorist****

A ****theorist**** is a person who develops, studies, or works mainly with theories.

Practice 14

> “He became an influential political ****theorist****.”

「他成為一位有影響力的政治****理論家****。」

Practice 15

> “Several educational ****theorists**** have examined this question.”

「幾位教育****理論家****都研究過這個問題。」

****theorist = 研究或建立某個領域理論的人****

Related form: ****theorize / theorise****

****Theorize**** means to develop or suggest a theory.

Practice 16

> “Researchers ****theorized**** that the change was caused by temperature.”

「研究人員****推測 / 提出理論****認為這個變化是由溫度造成的。」

Practice 17

> “Scholars have long ****theorised**** about why the pattern appears.”

「學者長期以來一直****提出理論 / 推測****這個模式為何出現。」

****theorize / theorise = 根據資料或思考提出理論、解釋或推測****

Spelling:

* **theorize** — common in American English

* **theorise** — common in British English

Important distinction: **theory vs fact**

theory

= an explanatory framework or proposed explanation

fact

= something known or demonstrated to be true

However, in science, **theory** does **not** simply mean “a guess.” A scientific theory is a structured explanatory framework supported by evidence.

So:

> theory ≠ unsupported guess

This distinction is important for learners.

Important distinction: **theory vs hypothesis**

hypothesis

usually means a specific proposed explanation that can be tested.

theory

is generally broader and more developed, especially in academic/scientific use.

Very roughly:

> hypothesis = specific testable proposal

> theory = broader explanatory framework

But exact disciplinary usage can vary.

Important distinction: **theory vs idea**

idea

is extremely broad.

theory

usually involves some attempt to explain how or why something happens.

> “I have an idea.”

could be any thought.

> “I have a theory.”

suggests an explanation.

Important distinction: **theory vs principle**

principle

is a basic rule, law, or guiding idea.

theory

is a broader explanatory system that may contain several principles.

So:

> principle = 原則

> theory = 理論體系

Important distinction: **theory vs practice**

This is the key contrast in your passage.

theory

= abstract knowledge or principles

practice

= actual doing, application, or experience

> “In theory, it is simple.”

> “In practice, it is difficult.”

This is exactly the contrast your grandfather passage creates.

Countability note

Theory is countable when referring to one particular explanation/framework:

> a theory

> several theories

But it can also be uncountable when referring generally to abstract theoretical knowledge:

> “The course combines theory and practice.”

Here:

theory = 理論知識 , 整體概念

This is a useful learner distinction.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **theory**

* **theories**

* **theoretical**

* **theoretically**

* **theorist**

* **theorize / theorise**

Useful constructions include:

* scientific theory

* theory and practice

- * in theory
- * theory of...
- * my theory is that...
- * theoretical possibility

The Golden Manual recommends noting both grammatical behaviour and useful family extensions while keeping genuinely related uses grouped under broader semantic concepts.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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theory — explanatory system	用一組有系統的概念、原則或命題解釋某種現象的理論 / 學說
theory — abstract knowledge	抽象的知識、原則或概念，相對於實際操作與經驗
theory — proposed explanation	對事情原因提出的一種解釋或推測，未必已獲證實
in theory	從理論、原則或假設角度來看，而不一定等於實際情況
theoretical	與理論有關的；或只在理論上可能存在的
theorist	研究、建立或發展理論的人
theorize / theorise	提出、建立或推測某個理論 / 解釋

For your original sentence

> “He did not teach me through ****theory**** alone...”

The exact meaning is:

****theory = 抽象的道理、原則和知識，而不是親身實踐****

The sentence contrasts:

- > ****theory****
- > with
- > ****action, repetition, and example****

So the meaning is:

> ****祖父不是只把道理說給我聽，而是讓我透過實際行動和反覆練習真正學會。****

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****theory****:

1. ****a structured system of ideas explaining something****
2. ****abstract principles/knowledge contrasted with practice****
3. ****an unproven or proposed explanation in everyday use****

I would keep **in theory** under #2 and treat **theoretical, theoretically, theorist, theorize/theorise** as family extensions rather than inflate the core count.